



Game Design

SubThought Corporation
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Ité — For those who seek the throne.

1. Concept

Ìtẹ (Yoruba: "throne") is a chess-derived strategy game combining positional play with RPG combat, an economic system built on wùrà (gold), and diplomatic mechanics including ransoms and bribes. Pieces have individual statistics, accumulate wealth, and can be captured alive, ransomed, bribed to switch sides, or killed. Victory is not checkmate — it is conquest.

2. Game Modes

Mode	Board	Dead Zones	Placement	End Condition
2-player	8×8 (a–h, 1–8)	None	Top vs bottom	King captured or defeated
3-player	14×14 (a–n, 1–14)	3×3 corners	3 of 4 sides, random	Last king standing
4-player	14×14 (a–n, 1–14)	3×3 corners	4 sides, random	Last king standing
2v2 teams	14×14 (a–n, 1–14)	3×3 corners	Adjacent or opposite	Last team with king

Each player views the board with their army at the bottom. The board rotates per player perspective.

3. Game Options

Option	Choices	Default
Players	2 / 3 / 4 / 2v2	2
Terrain	Off / On	Off
Fog	Off / On	Off
Low Ground Penalty	Off / On (requires Terrain)	On
Team Position	Adjacent / Opposite (2v2 only)	Adjacent
Computer Players	0–4	0
Time	1/3/5/10/30 min + 0/2/5/10s increment	3 min + 2s

4. Player Pieces

The king is the most valuable target (100 wùrà) but fragile (10 HP). The queen is the bruiser — highest HP and highest attack. Standard chess movement applies to all pieces.

Piece	Qty	Wùrà	HP	Attack	Life
Pawn	8	2	3	2	3
Knight	2	3	4	3	4
Bishop	2	3	4	3	4
Rook	2	5	6	5	6
Queen	1	15	20	9	20
King	1	100	10	5	10

5. Economy

Wùrà (Yoruba: "gold") is the universal currency. Every piece carries its own wùrà purse. The king starts with 100 wùrà as the primary war chest (the treasury). Sources: starting value, defeating opponents, ransom payments, bribe payments, taxing pieces (Tax moves wùrà from a piece's purse to the king's treasury). Expenditures: upgrading at camp, bribing, paying ransom, promoting pawns, gifting pieces (Gift moves wùrà from the king's treasury to a piece's purse).

6. Turn Actions

Each turn, a player performs one action from the action panel:

Action	Description
Defeat	Battle: engage an opponent's piece with intent to kill
Capture	Battle: engage an opponent's piece with intent to take alive to jail
Demand	Parley: demand ransom for a jailed piece
Offer	Parley: offer to pay ransom for a limbo piece
Bribe	Parley: offer wùrà to turn an opponent's piece
Yield	Battle: surrender during combat
Fight	Battle: counter-attack during combat
Heal	Recuperate a piece's life points
Train	Spend wùrà at camp to upgrade a piece's attack or HP
Accept	Parley: accept a ransom
Reject	Parley: reject a ransom demand

Rounds: A round completes when all players have taken one turn. Non-moving pieces recuperate 1 life per round.

7. Combat System

Combat is initiated and resolved from the main game screen — there is no separate combat dialog. When a piece is moved onto an opponent's occupied square and the attacker selects Defeat or Capture, the defender's action panel activates Fight or Yield. Both pieces strike simultaneously. The winner takes the loser's wùrà. Bribe acceptance is probabilistic based on the target's life, wùrà, HP, and the bribe amount.

Information Asymmetry: You can see your own pieces' full statistics. Opponent pieces are opaque — you cannot see their stats. If Fog is enabled, you can only see squares adjacent to your own pieces.

8. Capture, Jail, and Ransom

Piece lifecycle: Camp → Deploy → Board → Combat → Limbo/Jail → Ransom → Camp → Deploy → Board. Three sections appear below the board: Camp (your reserves), Limbo (your pieces taken in battle — status unknown), and Jail (enemy prisoners you hold). Click a jailed piece to Demand ransom or Bribe to your side; click a limbo piece to Offer ransom. If the captor accepts your offer, you pay the agreed wùrà and your piece returns to Camp — if it is still alive. If the piece is dead, the gold is spent and nothing comes back. Offering ransom is a genuine gamble. Accept and Reject complete negotiations.

9. Ronin

When a king falls in multiplayer, all remaining pieces of that player immediately change to the Dawn color (purple). No overlay or announcement — the color change on the board is the signal. Those pieces are now ronin: emancipated warriors with no allegiance. Ronin are fierce fighters and may become very wealthy since they are no longer taxed by any king. They can combat any player and can be bribed by any player. In 2-player, the king falling ends the game.

10. Terrain System (Optional)

Terrain	Difficulty	Altitude	Character
Valley	1	1	Easy ground
Village	1	1	Easy ground
Water	2	0	Moderate cost, lowest
Hills	2	2	Moderate cost, high ground
Mountain	3	3	Expensive, dominant
Swamp	3	1	Expensive, no payoff

Moving into a square costs its difficulty in life. All pieces get +10 HP when terrain is active. When Low Ground Penalty is on (default), the lower piece's attack is reduced by the altitude difference. Higher ground always grants an attack bonus equal to the altitude difference.

11. User Interface

11.1 Design Language

Dark slate (#1A1A2E) background, gold (#D4AF37) accents, panel surfaces (#242440). Board uses classic green (#6B8F4E) and cream (#EEEEED2) squares. African-inspired diamond geometry on splash/menu backgrounds. Sans-serif throughout; serif display face for title wordmark.

11.2 Splash Screen

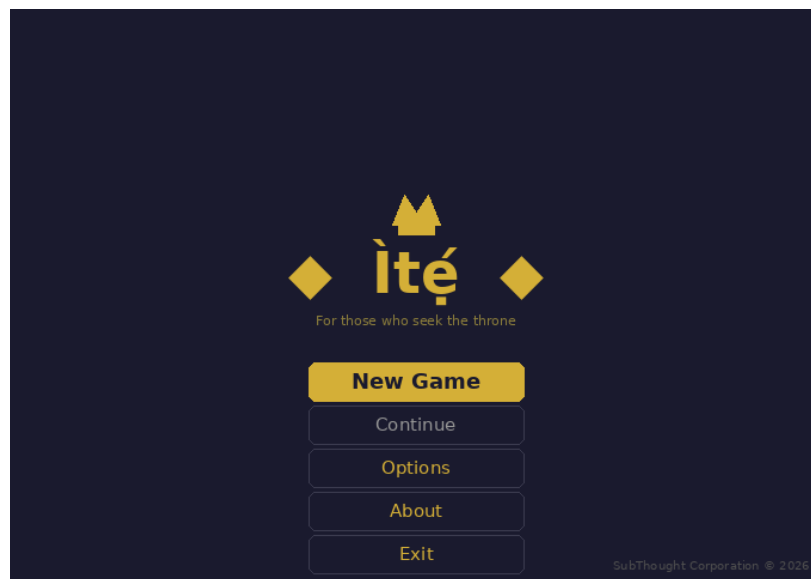


Figure 1. Splash screen

11.3 Game Setup Screen

Mode toggle cards (2P/3P/4P/2v2) with board dimensions. Player slots with Human/Computer dropdowns. AI level selector. Time control picker with increment. Advanced options panel reveals: Options toggles for Terrain, Low Ground Penalty, Fog, and Statistics; Sound selector (Off/Simple/Realistic); and Army Colors reference showing each player's color assignment.

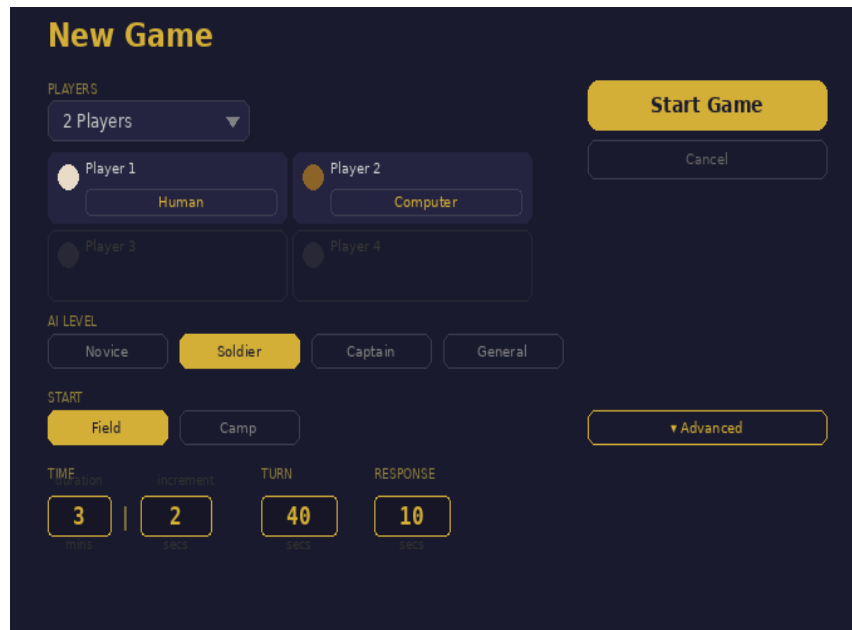


Figure 2a. Game setup screen (minimal)

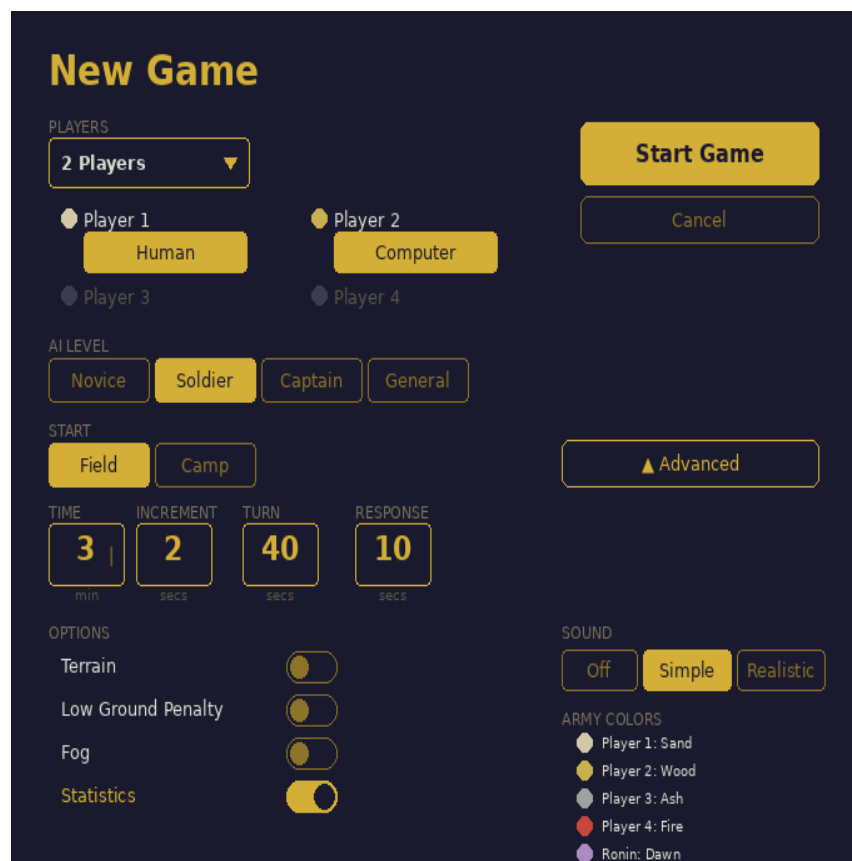


Figure 2b. Game setup screen (advanced options revealed)

11.4 Main Game Screen — 2-Player (8×8)

The entire game is played from a single screen. The layout has four regions:

Board (center): An 8×8 grid labeled a–h and 1–8. The player's army is always at the bottom. Each piece is displayed full-size on its square. On the player's own pieces, own pieces display a life bar at the bottom of the square only — no attack or wùrà numbers on the board. Click a piece to see full stats in the SELECTED panel. Opponent pieces show no statistics at all — just the piece graphic. The life bar fills proportionally to the piece's remaining life divided by its HP — no label, just the visual fill. Bar color: blue above 50%, purple below 50%, red below 25%. Selected pieces are highlighted with a gold border; valid move targets show gold dots.



Figure 3. 2-player game board — 8×8 with stat overlays, action panel, camp/jail

Action Panel (right): A Discord-style navigation sidebar on the left provides icons for New Game, Settings, Board view, and Help. The setup screen has minimal options (mode, players, AI level) with an Advanced button revealing additional settings: Start Position (Field or Camp — Camp requires deploying pieces to the board), Terrain, Low Ground Penalty, Fog, Sound (Off/Simple/Realistic), Time (duration|increment), Turn Duration (default 40 seconds — player

loses turn if no action taken), and Response Time (default 10 seconds). The action panel on the right has seven sections top to bottom.

SELECTED shows the last-clicked piece with stats (own only; enemy shows type and color). Own pieces display only a life bar on the board; enemy pieces show no stats.

WÚRÀ is a keyboard-editable amount field with an Ok button; clears on action selection. King's treasury funds Bribe, Demand, Offer, Tax, Gift; piece's purse funds Heal, Train.

COMBAT sets attack mode: Defeat (default), Capture, or Bribe.

PARLEY provides Demand and Offer.

MANAGE is a 2×2 grid: Tax, Gift, Heal, Train.

PROMOTE is a 2×2 grid: Knight (3w), Bishop (3w), Rook (5w), Queen (15w). Each button shows the cost from the king's treasury. The panel activates only when a pawn reaches the opponent's back rank and the king has sufficient wurà. If the king cannot afford any promotion, the panel stays dimmed and the pawn remains eligible for opponent bribe+promote.

RESPONSE is a 2×2 grid: Fight and Yield (top row), Reject and Accept (bottom row). All four always visible; the relevant pair lights up when the opponent initiates. Response is reactive — chosen after opponent acts, within the response time window. Defaults to Fight for combat and Reject for parley. A response does not count as a turn.

HISTORY at the bottom shows the scrollable move log with replay buttons (|< << < > >> >|) for stepping through game states.

RESIGN button below History.

Valid move indicators appear as small grey circles on destination squares when a piece is selected. Last opponent move shown as gold-shaded source and destination squares.

Players can bribe prisoners in Jail to switch sides — bribed prisoners move to Camp and can be deployed to the board, but loyalty is only as deep as the wurà: a bribed piece can always be bribed again.

Clicking any piece in a tray makes it the selected piece

Player Bars (top and bottom): Each shows player name, army color (Sand, Fire, Ash, or Wood), wùrà treasury, and clock timer. The active player's bar is gold-accented.

Below the board sit three vertically scrollable trays:

- Camp (reserves ready to deploy),

- Limbo (pieces taken in battle — status unknown). Offer ransom to recover them, but only if they're still alive.

- Jail (enemy prisoners — click to demand ransom or bribe to your side).

11.5 Board Architecture: Internal vs. Display

The internal board in the Premise knowledge base is larger than the displayed board. The KB stores full piece stats for all players, terrain data per square, fog state per player, ransom/bribe negotiation state, and the complete event log. The display board renders only what the current player is permitted to see: their own piece stats in full (life bar, attack number, wùrà number), opponent piece positions without stats, fog on unseen squares, and terrain when active.

11.6 Fog

When Fog is enabled, the player's own pieces and their immediate surroundings are fully visible at the bottom of the board. All other squares display as plain dark and light grey — the standard board pattern but in neutral grey tones with nothing on them. The grey squares are the fog: no texture, no smoke effect, just empty alternating grey where the green and cream would normally be. Opponent pieces are only revealed on squares the player can attack. The fog lifts as the player's pieces advance.



Figure 4. Board with Fog — opaque smokey squares hiding the upper board

11.6b Terrain Display

When Terrain is enabled, each square is tinted to indicate its terrain type and displays a small bitmap texture: rolling lines for valleys, tiny house shapes for villages, wave patterns for water, rounded bumps for hills, sharp peaks with snow caps for mountains, and bubbles with reeds for swamps. No text — the color and texture together identify each terrain type at a glance. All pieces receive +10 HP when terrain is active. Movement into a square costs its difficulty value in life.



Figure 4b. Board with Terrain — color-coded squares with terrain textures

11.7 Game Screen — Multiplayer (14×14)

The 3-player and 4-player boards use a 14×14 grid labeled a–n (columns) and 1–14 (rows), rendered at the same physical screen size as the 2-player board — squares are proportionally smaller but the overall layout is identical. The action panel remains on the right, Camp, Limbo, and Jail appear below the board, and player bars frame the top and bottom. Each corner has a 3×3 dead zone. Each player's army occupies one edge with a full 8-piece complement (columns 3–10 (centered)). Four player bars are split across the top and bottom edges of the board. The same stat overlays (life bar + attack and wùrà numbers) apply to the active player's own pieces.



Figure 5. 4-player board — 14×14, 3×3 corner dead zones, stat bars on own pieces

11.8 Game History

The game history is a scrollable region or popout panel accessible from the main screen. It records every action with round numbers, piece symbols, move notation (e.g. ♖g1→f3), and combat annotations: DEF (defeat), CAP (capture), BRIBE with amount, wùrà transfers (+2w), HP loss (-2HP), and jail transfers (→ JAIL). Playback controls allow reviewing the game move by move.

In 2-player mode the history has two player columns:

GAME HISTORY			
Rd	Sundiata (Ivory)	Shaka (Black)	
1.	e2→e4	e7→e5	
2.	Ng1→f3	Nb8→c6	
3.	Bf1→c4	Nc6→d4	
4.	Nf3→d4	Nd4 ♚	-2 HP
5.	Nd4	+2w	d7→d5
6.	Qd1→h5	e5→e4	
7.	Qh5→f7	CAPTURE	Pf7 →JAIL
8.		DEMAND Pf7 5w	
9.			REJECT
10.	Qf7→f5	Bc8→f5	

Figure 6a. 2-player game history

In 3+ player mode the history expands to four columns, tracking cross-player bribes, yields, captures, and ronin events:

GAME HISTORY — 4 PLAYER				
Rd	Sundiata	Shaka	Amina	Mansa
1.	e2→e4	e7→e5	a5→a7	n5→n7
2.	Ng1→f3	Nb8→c6	Nb3→c5	Nl3→k5
3.	Bf1→c4	d7→d5	Bb3→d5	Bl3→j5
4.	Nf3→d5	DEFEAT	Pd5 ♚	-2HP
5.	Nd5	+2w	Qd8→f6	Be5→c7
6.	c2→c3	Bc8→g4		YIELD
7.	d2→d4	Qf6→f2		→CAPTURED Bj5→Mansa
8.	Qd1→h5		DEMAND Bg4 4w	g7→g5
9.		OFFER 3w	REJECT	
10.	Ke1→d2	Qf2→f1		Rn8→n5
11.			RONIN ♚	
12.	Kd2→e3			Rn5→d5
				BRIBE 2w

Figure 6b. 4-player game history

11.9 Ransom and Bribe

Ransom negotiation is conducted entirely from the main game screen. The Parley section provides Demand and Offer buttons, a Piece field (auto-populated by the last clicked piece), and a Wùrà amount input field. Accept and Reject buttons sit beneath to finalize negotiations. A successful bribe is signaled by the piece changing to the bribing player's color; no change means the bribe failed.

11.11 End Game

Victory screen shows the winning player's banner, total wùrà, pieces captured/defeated, and a timeline of key events. Play Again returns to setup. Replay watches the full game.

12. Technology Stack

Layer	Technology	Role
Game Logic	Premise theories (.theory)	Board state, combat, economy, AI rules
Bridge	Premise packages (.package)	C# DLL adapter to web frontend
Frontend	TypeScript React	Board rendering, UI, animations
Communication	WebSocket	Real-time state sync

13. Computer Players

Level	Name	Description
1	Novice	Random valid moves
2	Soldier	Basic tactics, defends king
3	Captain	Positional play, terrain, economy
4	General	Full strategy: bribes, ransoms, upgrades, low ground

14. Premise Architecture

File	Type	Purpose
ite.theory	Theory	Core game logic
ite-rules.theory	Theory	AI rules
ite-terrain.theory	Theory	Terrain/movement
ite-ui.package	Package	C# bridge to React
ite-net.package	Package	Network multiplayer (future)

15. Tuning Variables

Variable	Current	Notes
Base HP	3–20	Combat duration
Base attack	2–9	Lethality
Terrain HP bonus	+10	Cover travel costs
Low ground penalty	–difference	Per altitude level; default On
Recuperation	1/round	Healing speed
Bribe formula	$f(\text{life}, \text{wùrà}, \text{HP}, \text{offer})$	Acceptance curve
Training cost	TBD	Wùrà per upgrade

16. Glossary

Term	Meaning
Ìtẹ̀	Throne (Yoruba). The game.
Wùrà	Gold (Yoruba). The currency.
Ronin	Masterless pieces after a king falls.
Camp	Off-board staging area.
Jail	Opponent pieces you hold. Click to Demand ransom.
Limbo	Your pieces taken in battle. Status unknown — Offer ransom to recover, but only if still alive.
Deploy	Move from camp to board.
Train	Spend wùrà to upgrade at camp.
Bribe	Parley: offer wùrà to turn a piece.
Ransom	Negotiate return of a jailed piece.
Yield	Surrender in combat.
Fight	Counter-attack in combat.
Fog	Opaque grey squares hiding unseen areas.
Dead Zone	Impassable 3×3 corner regions on 14×14 board.

Ìtẹ̀ — For those who seek the throne.
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